

Cultural Cooperation between Iran and the Indian Subcontinent: The Case of Bangladesh

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Cultural Dialogue between Iran and the Subcontinent: Spirituality and Sufism

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ABSTRACT

Although Iran does not share a common border with Bangladesh as it does with Pakistan and Afghanistan, Bangladesh is an important Asian neighbor for Iran. Pakistan being a very close neighbor has been greatly influenced by the Iranian culture and values, and Bangladesh being a part of Pakistan until 1971 was also influenced by the same forces. The majority of the people in both countries are Muslims. Also there are many similarities between the two countries based on language and literature; art and culture; cuisine, food habit and hospitality; and diplomatic policies regarding relationship with neighboring countries. This paper examines the historical cultural relationship between Iran and the Indian subcontinent with special focus on Bangladesh and attempts to identify the obstacles and impediments that hindered the development of a more congenial and stronger cultural ties between the two countries. The paper offers a set of recommendations to fortify the cultural bond between Iran and Bangladesh in the future.

INTRODUCTION

The Indian subcontinent has been extremely important to Iran because of the geographical proximity, trade relations and historic cultural ties. This paper focuses on Iran's past, present and future cultural ties with the Indian subcontinent with specific focus on Bangladesh. Historically, the Indian subcontinent comprised of three countries, namely India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Before 1971, Bangladesh was a part of Pakistan. After the emergence of Bangladesh as an independent country in 1971, the cultural ties between Pakistan and Iran took a new turn. The diplomatic ties between India and Iran also went through a transformation because of the new economic and political relations of India with Pakistan and Bangladesh which affected the relationship of these countries with Iran as well.

Before 1971, Pakistan consisted of West Pakistan and East Pakistan (current Bangladesh) and was a close neighbor of Iran having 830 km common border with Pakistan. Iran has a rich cultural, territorial and religious history that had a great influence on Pakistan as its neighboring country. Although Iran's cultural influence on West Pakistan was immediate due to geographic proximity, East Pakistan being a part of Pakistan at that time could not stay immune to such influences. After Bangladesh became independent in 1971, some of these influences sustained and continued to affect the life and culture of Bangladeshi people.

DIPLOMATIC RELATIONS BETWEEN BANGLADESH AND IRAN

Bangladesh became independent on the 26th of March 1971 with the onset of a heavily blood-shedding war against Pakistan that ended with victory on the 16th of December the same year. Three million Bangladeshi people were killed during this war and three hundred thousand women were raped and tortured by the Pakistani occupation forces. Because of the strong diplomatic ties with Pakistan for a long period of time, Iran took three years to recognize Bangladesh as an independent country on the 22nd of February in 1974. Diplomatic missions were opened thereafter between the two countries. Several high level visits were exchanged at the ministerial level. In 1995, Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani became the first President of Iran to visit Bangladesh. Begum Khaleda Zia, the then Prime Minister of Bangladesh attended the Islamic Summit in Tehran in 1997 and during her visit she discussed various aspects of bilateral relations with the President of Iran. There exists a joint Bangladesh-Iran Economic Cooperation Forum at the Ministers' level to strengthen bilateral cooperation. Iran agreed to construct cement factory and food grain storage in Bangladesh. Bangladesh signed a Memorandum of Understanding on fisheries and livestock with Iran in February 2000 during the visit to Tehran by Bangladesh Foreign Minister. In 2004, Bangladesh introduced special postage stamps in commemoration of Iran-Bangladesh friendship with the pictures of noted Iranian poet Hafez Shirazi and national poet of Bangladesh Kazi Nazrul Islam. Bangladesh and Iran signed a preferential trade accord in July 2006 which removed non-tariff barriers, with a view to eventually establishing a free trade agreement. Many Bangladeshi people have been working in various employment sectors in Iran. A large number of them are medical doctors.

The current Prime Minister of Bangladesh, Sheikh Hasina, attended the 16th Summit of Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) in Tehran in August 2013. While attending the NAM Summit, the Bangladesh Prime Minister met with a number of heads of states/governments including the top leaders of the host country Iran. She met the supreme spiritual leader Ayatollah Sayyed Ali Hosseini Khamenei and the President Dr. Mahmoud Ahmadinejad. During their meeting, the supreme spiritual leader of Iran pointed to the influential role of Bangladesh as a member of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM) as well as the D8 Group. The Iranian leader hoped that cooperation among Islamic countries would uphold the interests of the Muslim nations and increase their power across the world. He also pointed to historical and cultural commonalities between Iran and Bangladesh and noted that profound cultural ties provide a very good ground for the promotion of political, international, economic and social cooperation between Tehran and Dhaka. The Prime Minister of Bangladesh assured the supreme leader of Iran of Bangladesh's full support to Iran during its NAM chairmanship over the next three years. She further expressed that Bangladesh would like to strengthen ties with Iran in various fields, particularly in economic, trade and cultural sectors. During her meeting with the Iranian President, the Bangladesh Prime Minister discusses issues relating to bilateral interests. She noted that Bangladesh maintained its macroeconomic stability despite the global economic recession.

COMMON FOUNDATIONS OF CULTURAL TIES BETWEEN IRAN AND BANGLADESH

Bangladesh's cultural relations with Iran are rooted in history. The historic region of Bengal, which is today constituted mostly by present day Bangladesh, has had strong cultural relationships with Iran. Bengal (currently the territory of Bangladesh) saw a great influx of Persian scholars, artists, merchants, administrators, warriors and tourists during the Mughal Empire. Some of Bengal's once powerful landed aristocrats are believed to be descendents of many of the rich Persian immigrants. In modern Bangladesh, many renowned business houses like Ispahani are owned by families hailing from Iran. A few Iranians who migrated to Bengal eventually got married to Bengali women and settled in Bangladesh.

Many Persian scholars fostered Persian poetry and literature in the country. Persian was the official language of Bengal for over 600 years (until 1832) and Persian literature significantly influenced Bengali literature. Due to the large immigration of Iranians, many Persian words entered the Bengali language and literature, such as awaj (sound), aram (comfort), khub (very), garam (hot), chakri (job), namaz (prayer), Khoda Hafez (May God take care of you) and many other words of common use. In recent years, there has been a huge influx of private universities in Bangladesh. Some of these universities have opened up language centers where Persian language is taught. A few of them have established Department of Persian Studies or Persian Language Center.

A significant number of Muslim poets were heavily inspired by rich Persian poetry and culture. Poets such as Hafez, Saadi and Omar Khayyam had a great influence on Bengali scholars in appreciating the esoteric side of the religion of Islam. In the 1930s, the world-acclaimed Nobel-laureate Bengali poet Rabindranath Tagore visited Iran and met its senior leaders. Kazi Nazrul Islam, the national poet of Bangladesh, had greatly used Persian language and literature to develop Bengali ghazals and poetry.

Compared to Bangladesh, the two other countries of the Indian subcontinent, namely Pakistan and India have more cultural similarities with Iran mainly because of the geographic proximity that make these two countries closer neighbors to Iran. The main language in Pakistan is Urdu which has borrowed many terms and words from Persian language. In fact, Urdu acts as substitute of Persian in the Indian subcontinent. The Hazara tribe in Pakistan still speaks Persian. Until the 19th century, Persian was widely spoken in many parts of the Indian subcontinent. Before 1757, the Indian subcontinent had been part of the Mughal empire for centuries. Iranian migrants and Islamic preachers had a big impact on the culture and civilization of this region. There are many similarities in architecture, painting, weaving, pottery and calligraphy between Iran and the Indian subcontinent. The way Tajmehal and large gardens were designed in India and Pakistan followed the style and pattern of Iranian architecture. Many historical buildings in Pakistan including Shalimar gardens reflect Persian architecture.

Many games and sports such as football, swimming, shooting, polo and boxing are equally popular in Iran and Bangladesh. Food habit and cooking style are also similar. Use of

meat, kebab, biryani, jafrani, tikka and salads are very common in both countries. Cuisine in Iran is one of the oldest in the civilized world having similarities with Bangladeshi cuisine. Baking of bread and cooking of rice have similarity. The traditional sweet dishes are common between the two countries. Meat is an important part of cuisine. Both countries are promoting tourism. Cultural exchange visits are often held. Since the majority of the people in both countries are Muslims, there are many similarities in terms of religious rituals, traditions and practices. Most of the marriage ceremonies have the same style in Bangladesh and Iran. Ramadan, sehri, iftaar, chand raat, Eid-e-Miladunnabi, Ashura, Shab-e-Barat, Eid celebrations and other religious ceremonies are commonly celebrated in both countries. In recent times, wearing hijab has become very popular among Bangladeshi women and Iranian hijab is the most favorite to most women. Iranian triangular scarf is also becoming very popular to Bangladeshi women, especially to the young girls. The Iranian carpet is the most popular in Bangladesh. The elite people of the society always want to have Iranian carpet in their houses, although some these carpets are extremely expensive. Islamic ethical and social relationships, the relationship between the individual and the society, ownership of property, marital relationships and the relationships beyond wedlock are governed by the same Islamic rules and policies both in Bangladesh and Iran.

There are similarities between Iran and Bangladesh in terms of literary practices. Poetry is highly respected in both countries. A famous poet in Bangladesh has composed a poem on the Iranian epic “Shahnama” by Ferdowsi; the poet sincerely hopes that A Bangladeshi poet would get inspired by this great Persian work and write an epic in Bengali to elevate the image and position of Bangladesh to the same height as was done by Ferdowsi of Iran. Omar Khayyam is very popular in Bangladesh as is Nazrul in Iran. Iranian women are considered very pretty and attractive in Bangladesh, and when a Bangladeshi woman is found very pretty she is compared to an Iranian woman. Poet Nazrul composed a song and he copied the tune of this song from an Iranian song. Both of these songs are very popular in Bangladesh and Iran. Persian language and literature is very popular in Bangladesh. Some universities have established Center for Persian Studies.

The importance of Persian language and culture in Bangladesh can be assumed by several reasons. National poet Nazrul Islam has used many Persian words in his famous poems in Bengali. Later on these words were adopted as Bengali words. At several shrines the music

played was brought from Persia. A vast majority of the Muslims in Bangladesh are Sunni and are followers of Imam Abu Hanifa, an Islamic scholar of Persian origin. A significant number of Iranian students come to Bangladesh for higher studies. They infuse Iranian language, culture and values through close interactions with their friends in Bangladesh. Many Sufi orders and the exponents of the important scholars of jurisprudence came from Persia to Bangladesh. Most of them were Persians who developed their thoughts in a Persian environment. Many Iranian professors have been teaching in various U.S. universities for a long time. There is a large number of Bangladeshi students who study in the U.S. and are influenced by the personality and personal values of their Iranian teachers. When these students come back to Bangladesh after their higher studies, they use their Iranian professors as role models and try to imitate them in various aspects of their life. Each and every year, the Iranian media delegations and cultural activists have been visiting Bangladesh. These visits have played an effective role in promoting mutual understanding and projection of better image of Bangladesh to Iran.

The Iranian Embassy in Dhaka and the Iranian Cultural Center have been playing a very important role in promoting Iranian culture and values in Bangladesh. The Embassy invites diplomats and scholars from Iran to Bangladesh and organizes visits to business and government offices and universities where they exchange views with the Bangladeshi leaders. Sometimes, they deliver lectures on the issues of international interest, followed by Iranian cultural programs. The Iranian Cultural Center organizes discussion programs on the occasions of Nowroz, Ashura, Eid-e-Miladunnabi, Ramadan, Iran Republic Day, birth and death anniversaries of the founder of modern Iran Imam Ayatollah Khomeini, national days of the Palestinians and the Kurds, etc. These programs play a vital role in exerting a great influence on life and culture of Bangladeshi people. The Iranian School in Dhaka also plays a very important role in inculcating Iranian culture and values among Bangladeshi children and their parents.

OBSTACLES TO PROMOTING CULTURAL TIES BETWEEN BANGALDESH AND IRAN

In recent years, terrorism and Islamism have been mixed up by some people in Bangladesh. Since Iran is a strong Muslim country dedicated to upholding Islamic values and

principles, some people are afraid to adopt Islamic culture and values because they think that if they do it, they will be labeled as terrorists. About a couple of years back, some young militants killed more than twenty persons including foreign nationals at a restaurant named Holy Artisan in Dhaka in the name of Jihad. As a result, any kind of Islamic gatherings are being discouraged by the government and the law enforcement agencies, and attendance in any Islamic discussion programs including similar programs organized by the Iranian Embassy or the Iranian Cultural Center has been very poor.

The adversarial diplomatic relationship between Iran and the U.S.A. also has a negative impact on cultural exchange between Bangladesh and Iran. Since Bangladesh is still an underdeveloped country, many people have a strong desire to go to the U.S.A. for work and eventually settle there permanently. If the U.S. immigration officials find any evidence that shows an individual's linkage with Iran, there is a high possibility that the application for immigration to the U.S. will be denied. Even if someone with an Iranian visa on his/her passport wants to visit U.S.A. on a tourist visa, the person has to go through a rigorous investigation process and in many cases the U.S. visa is denied. So, the general people do not want to visit Iran for cultural exchange, higher education or employment. The government of Bangladesh also wants to maintain a cordial relationship with the U.S.A., which discourages the government to strengthen its ties with Iran.

Although both Bangladesh and Iran are Muslim countries, the majority of the Muslims in Iran are Shiite while Bangladesh is dominated by the Sunni Muslims. In fact, there is no fundamental difference between the Shiite and Sunni Muslims. But there has been a strong Western propaganda that these two sects are completely different and they are hostile to each other. Since many Bangladeshi people are not highly educated and their religious knowledge is also poor, they think that the Shiite Muslims are their enemies, or at least not their friends. This has created some hostility and a large number of Sunni Muslims try to avoid cultural activities, programs and events organized by the Iranian Shiite Muslims.

Iran, despite being a close neighbor to Bangladesh, has failed to attract the Bangladeshi people to travel to Iran to strengthen cultural exchange or find attractive employment

opportunities. Many people in Bangladesh expect Iran to provide leadership to the Muslim world. Unfortunately the Muslim world is not united. Even Saudi Arabia created bitter relationship with Iran and did not allow the Iranian to go to Saudi Arabia to perform hajj. Such bitterness among Muslim nations strengthens the hands of the enemies of Islam. Diplomatic relations between Bangladesh and Iran needs to ameliorate.

Most of the Iranian officials of the Embassy of Iran and Iranian Cultural Center in Dhaka speak Persian. In most of the cases, they need an interpreter to translate their speeches into English or Bengali. In Bangladesh, a large number of people understand English. With a huge influx of English medium schools and mushrooming private universities, where the medium of instruction is English, Bangladeshi people expect that foreign guests or visitors would speak in English and directly communicate to the people of Bangladesh without the help of an interpreter.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Iran has all the potential to provide leadership to the Muslim world. Many Iranian professors are teaching in top universities in the U.S. and Europe. So, the first strategy would be to develop a cordial and congenial diplomatic relations with each country. Cultural ties with Bangladesh or any other country would largely depend on the image and reputation of Iran to the international community. The United States now intends to dominate the whole world and the Trump government has taken an explicit stand against the Muslims. The foreign policy of Bangladesh is founded on the motto of “Friendship to all and malice to none”. Iran should adopt the same policy. Their vision should be to provide leadership to the world—not by the power of weaponry but by the power of knowledge and intellect. Global acceptability of Iran as a role model would encourage other countries, especially the third world nations like Bangladesh, to strengthen their economic and cultural bond with Iran.

The diplomatic relations between Iran and Bangladesh must be strengthened. Bangladesh’s major resources are skilled and unskilled manpower, garments, frozen food, medicine, paper and paper-made materials, jute and jute goods, etc. The Iranian government should import these items from Bangladesh. There are many medical colleges in Bangladesh that are producing a huge number of medical doctors. In the past, many Bangladesh doctors came to

Iran to practice medicine. The Iranian government should undertake rejuvenated efforts to attract Bangladeshi doctors to Iran again. There should be more frequent visits by the heads of governments and at the ministerial levels of both countries. This will strengthen the friendship and mutual understanding between the two countries which will eventually promote cultural exchange and ties.

The government of Iran can identify certain sectors where Bangladeshi workers can find employment opportunities. A huge number of unskilled workers from Bangladesh have been working in many countries in the Middle East. Especially, Bangladeshi housemaids, nurses, and menial workers are catering the employment needs of the Middle East countries the most. In many cases, Bangladeshi workers are not happy in the Middle East because they are not treated well, physically and mentally tortured and are underpaid. Iran can play a vital role in absorbing Bangladeshi workers in the above sectors, which will eventually promote cultural ties. When these people will go back to Bangladesh, they will disseminate positive information about Iranian people and culture.

In addition to government initiatives, a number of private initiatives may be undertaken to promote cultural exchange between the two countries. Universities, non-government organizations, and business organizations in both countries can invite academicians, artists and research scholars under a mutual exchange program for short visits. During such visits, the invitees can serve as resource persons in seminars, participate in TV talk shows and organize cultural events. This will improve the understanding of the people of both countries about the culture and lifestyles of the people of each country. Iranian universities should organize international conferences more frequently on different disciplines including basic science, social science, engineering and technology, humanities, and business administration. This will promote cultural ties across nations.

Business organizations can also play a major role in promoting cultural ties between Iran and Bangladesh. In addition to SAARC Chamber of Commerce, there are some joint chambers of commerce operating in Bangladesh such as Tajikistan-Bangladesh Chamber of Commerce, Malaysia-Bangladesh Chamber of Commerce, etc. An Iran-Bangladesh Chamber of Commerce

may also be formed that will help in promoting business exchange between the two countries that will eventually strengthen the cultural ties as well.

The activities of the Embassy of Iran, Iranian Cultural Center, and the Iranian School in Dhaka should strengthen and expand their scope of activities. The Iranian staff in all these places should be well-versed in English and deliver speeches without the assistance of an interpreter. The Embassy of Iran should undertake initiatives to facilitate more exchange of visiting scholars between the two countries. The Iranian Cultural Center should organize a lot more cultural activities that will showcase and expose the Bangladeshi people to Iranian art, music, dance and architecture. A large number of the members of the civil society should be invited to such programs, including high government officials as distinguished guests. The Iranian Qari's (Quran reciters) are excellent. The Center can provide Qari's to different programs organized by the government and non-government organizations. Most of the programs in Bangladesh starts with recitation from the Holy Quran. The Iranian Cultural Center may consider opening additional branches in major cities such as Chittagong, Rajshahi, Khulna and Mymensingh. During Ramadan, Eid festivals and Nowroz, all dignitaries of the civil society should be invited. Just sending an invitation card or a cell-phone message is not enough. A staff from the Center should call each invitee and confirm their participation in all important programs organized by the Iranian Cultural Center. The Iranian school in Dhaka should undertake additional endeavors to reach out to more parents and encourage them to get their children admitted into the school. The school curriculum should emphasize on teaching English, Bengali and Persian simultaneously. The quality of teachers and administrators should be enhanced through better recruitment and training.

The biggest challenge in promoting cultural ties between Iran and any country of the world is the negative propaganda being done by the U.S. and the Western countries against Iran. This has thrown Iran into a vicious cycle. In order to get out of this vicious cycle, Iran must attain global leadership through an intellectual revolution. Iranian people are highly talented. Iranian scientists, engineers, architects, artists and professors can play a vital role in breaking the negative stereotypes that the U.S. and its allies have been propagating against Iran. The first step is to take the leadership of the Islamic world through continuous diplomatic dialogue with each

Muslim country. Once the Muslim world is united under the leadership of Iran, Iran's bargaining power will increase significantly and they will be able to bring about a change in the world order.

CONCLUSIONS

Bangladesh and Iran have centuries-old cultural commonalities. However, in recent times Iran's image as a terrorist country portrayed by the U.S. and its Western allies and the U.S. economic embargo on Iran have created insurmountable obstacles to building and promoting economic and cultural ties with Iran by any country. All Muslim countries of the world should denounce false portrayal of Iran as a terrorist country and come forward to develop an amicable diplomatic and cultural relationship with Iran. Muslim countries which are economically more vulnerable are in a worse situation because they cannot take an open stand against the U.S. Therefore, Iran should change its strategy and move forward slowly towards achieving global leadership through an intellectual revolution. This will eventually help Iran to develop an amicable cultural relationship with all nations of the world. Iran Embassies, Iranian Cultural Centers, and Iranian schools in foreign countries can play a vital role in promoting cultural ties with that particular country. The same strategies can be applied to Bangladesh with customization in certain areas as mentioned in this paper. This is how Bangladesh can become a great friend of Iran with mutual collaboration and ties in the economic, political and cultural arena.